Foreign Funding Allowed: In 2018 budget, the receiving of foreign funds by the political parties has been allowed. In other words, the political parties can now receive funds from the foreign companies. Accordingly, the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010, has been amended. Under this amendment, the definition of a foreign company has been modified.

Election Laws (Amendment) Act, 2021: This Amendment Act provided for the following electoral reform:

1. It enabled the linking of electoral roll data with the Aadhaar ecosystem in order to curb the menace of multiple enrolment of the same person in different places.

2. It specified the 1st January, 1st April, 1st July and 1st October in a calendar year as qualifying dates in relation to the preparation or revision of electoral rolls. Before this, only the 1st January of the year was the qualifying date in this regard.

3. It allowed spouses of service voters[31] to cast their vote in person or through postal ballot. To this effect, it substituted the word 'wife' with the word 'spouse' in order to make the election laws gender-neutral.

4. It enabled the requisition of premises that are needed for the purpose of counting, storage of voting machines (including VVPATs) and poll-related material after a poll has taken place and also for the purpose of accommodation of security forces and polling personnel. Before this, the requisition of premises was allowed for the purpose of being used as polling stations or storage of ballot boxes after a poll has taken place. In other words, this Amendment Act has expanded the grounds for the requisition of premises.

[1]In 1998, the BJP-led Government appointed an eight-member committee on state funding of elections under the chairmanship of Indrajit Gupta, a former Home Minister. The committee submitted its report in 1999. It upheld the argument for introduction of state funding of elections. It stated that state funding of elections is constitutionally and legally justified and is in public interest.

[2]*Representation of the People (Amendment) Act* of *1988, with effect from 1989.*

[3]*Ibid*.

[4]*Ibid*.

[5]*Ibid*.

[6]Annual Report 2013–14, Ministry of Law and Justice, Government of India, p. 67.

[7]*Representation of the People (Amendment) Act*, 1996.

[8]*Presidential and Vice-Presidential Elections (Amendment) Act*, 1997.

[9]*Representation of the People (Amendment) Act*, 1998.

[10]*Representation of the People (Amendment) Act*, 1999.

[11]*Election Laws (Amendment) Act*, 2003 and Conduct of Elections (Amendment) Rules, 2003.

[12]*Representation of the People (Amendment) Act*, 2003.